

## Lesson 09

# Cross-cultural business situations



## Case study

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### The Delayed Launch (Voice Recording Transcript)

"Catalyst Creative Solutions," an IT company based in the United States, was contracted by Kaito Electronics, a Japanese company, to develop a new cloud-based data management system. The initial project deadline was set for three months.

The U.S. team, accustomed to direct communication and frequent updates, sent daily emails detailing their progress and highlighting any potential roadblocks. They also scheduled weekly video conferences to discuss the project.

Kaito Electronics, however, preferred less frequent communication and valued a more hierarchical decision-making process. They found the daily emails overwhelming and the direct questions during the video conferences somewhat abrupt. They also expected a more formal, detailed report closer to the deadline.

As the deadline approached, Kaito Electronics expressed concern about the project's progress, citing a lack of detailed documentation and a perceived lack of understanding of their specific needs. The U.S. team, confused by the client's sudden dissatisfaction, pointed to the daily emails and weekly meetings as evidence of their consistent communication.

Ultimately, the project launch was delayed by two weeks, leading to frustration on both sides. The U.S. team felt their efforts were unappreciated, while Kaito Electronics felt their communication preferences and cultural expectations were disregarded.

## Case study analysis:

1. What contributed to the project's delay?
2. How did the differing expectations regarding project updates and documentation impact the client's perception of the US team's progress?
3. In what ways did the US team's approach conflict with the Japanese client's cultural preferences?
4. What steps could have been taken to better understand and adapt to cultural norms and communication preferences?
5. How could both teams have clarified expectations to prevent misunderstandings and ensure a smoother project timeline?



## Communication Essentials

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- **Do Your Research:**
  - Before interacting, learn about the client's or team's culture.
  - Focus on communication styles, formality, and expectations.
- **Communicate Clearly and Respectfully:**
  - Avoid jargon and use simple language.
  - Be mindful of body language (even in video calls).
  - Ask clarifying questions to ensure mutual understanding.
- **Build Relationships:**
  - Take time to establish trust. Show genuine interest in learning about their culture.
  - Be patient and understanding.
- **Adapt Your Approach:**
  - Be flexible and willing to adjust your communication and work style.
  - Be open to feedback and learn from your mistakes.

- **Clarify Expectations:**

- Explicitly discuss deadlines, communication frequency, and project goals upfront.
- Use phrases like "Let's clarify expectations" to avoid misunderstandings.

- **Understand Negotiation Styles:**

- Be aware that "Different cultures have different approaches to negotiations."
- Be prepared to adapt your negotiation tactics.

**In essence:**

- Listen actively.
- Be aware of your own cultural biases.
- Show respect.
- Be flexible.



## Practice

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### A. Multiple Choice

**Choose the letter of the correct answer.**

**1. Which of the following is crucial for building cross-cultural trust?**

- a) Ignoring cultural differences.
- b) Consistent and transparent communication.
- c) Imposing your own cultural norms.
- d) Avoiding direct communication.

**2. When working with a client who prefers indirect communication, you should:**

- a) Use very direct and blunt language.
- b) Avoid asking clarifying questions.

- c) Pay close attention to implied meanings and context.
- d) Overlook any non-verbal cues.

**3. Understanding "formality levels" is important because:**

- a) It helps you avoid using jargon.
- b) It ensures you use appropriate language and behavior.
- c) It simplifies complex technical concepts.
- d) It allows you to ignore cultural differences.

**4. An "international mindset" includes:**

- a) A belief that your culture is superior.
- b) An openness to diverse cultures and global perspectives.
- c) Ignoring different negotiation styles.
- d) Assuming everyone communicates the same way.

**5. Which phrase best expresses the goal of clarifying expectations in cross-cultural communication?**

- a) "We will proceed according to our standard procedures."
- b) "Let's clarify expectations to avoid misunderstandings."
- c) "Your culture is not relevant to this project."
- d) "We do not need to discuss these issues."

**B. Complete the sentences with the correct word or phrase about the key principles of cross-cultural business situations.**

1. Different cultures have different \_\_\_\_\_ to negotiations.
2. Being aware of \_\_\_\_\_ can prevent misinterpretations during international meetings.
3. It's important to \_\_\_\_\_ cultural differences when working with multinational teams.
4. Developing an \_\_\_\_\_ is crucial for success in global IT projects.
5. To ensure a smooth project, let's \_\_\_\_\_ expectations to avoid misunderstandings.

**CHOICES:**

*clarify*

*approaches*

*respect*

*communication styles*

*intercultural awareness*



## Production

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**Share brief experiences working with people from different cultures.**

Think of a specific situation where you noticed a cultural difference impacting communication or teamwork. It could be a positive or challenging experience.

**In 1-2 minutes, describe:**

1. The cultural difference you observed.
2. How it affected the situation.
3. What you learned or how you adapted.





## Key Vocabulary

| Word/Phrase                                                            | Use                                                                                      | Example                                                                                                       |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Negotiation styles</b>                                              | The varying approaches used when discussing to reach an agreement.                       | "Different cultures have different approaches to negotiations."                                               |
| <b>Formality levels</b>                                                | The degree to which formal language and behavior are used.                               | "Understanding <b>formality levels</b> is essential when communicating with clients from different cultures." |
| <b>International mindset</b>                                           | A global perspective and openness to diverse cultures.                                   | "Developing an <b>international mindset</b> is crucial for success in global IT projects."                    |
| <b>Build cross-cultural trust</b>                                      | To establish confidence and reliability with people from different cultural backgrounds. | "Consistent and transparent communication helps <b>build cross-cultural trust</b> ."                          |
| <b>"Let's clarify expectations to avoid misunderstandings."</b>        | An expression used to ensure mutual understanding and prevent potential issues.          | "To ensure a smooth project, <b>let's clarify expectations to avoid misunderstandings</b> ."                  |
| <b>"Different cultures have different approaches to negotiations."</b> | An expression acknowledging the diversity in how agreements are reached across cultures. | " <b>Different cultures have different approaches to negotiations</b> , so it's important to be flexible."    |



## Homework

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### **Task: "Cultural Reflection"**

Think of one instance, real or imagined, where a cultural misunderstanding could occur in an IT work environment (e.g., a virtual team meeting, a client email, a project deadline).

#### **In 2-3 sentences, describe:**

- The potential cultural difference involved.
- How it might lead to a misunderstanding.

Then, in 1-2 sentences, explain how you would apply ONE of the key principles we discussed today to prevent or resolve the misunderstanding. Please post your response in the online forum or learning platform. This should take no more than 5 minutes."